

Pothos (Devil's Ivy, Golden Pothos): House Plant How-To

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Description

Pothos (*Epipremnum aureum*), commonly referred to as devil's ivy, golden pothos, and hunter's rove, is a great starter plant for the beginner.

There are fifteen species. It originates in Southeast Asia, Indonesia, and the Solomon Islands. In its native habitat, it is found as a ground cover (or a scrambler) that winds its way up the trees.

As an indoor plant, this trailing vine has large, thick, waxy-textured, heart-shaped, bright-green leaves.

Variegated varieties have blotchy yellow, white, or cream markings in the leaves. It grows quickly, as much as 12 to 18 inches in length in a month.

Plant Care

- **Soil:** Pothos does best in well-drained potting soil.
- **Water:** Thoroughly water the plant and let the soil dry out between waterings. Continuous damp soil will promote rotting roots. Black spots on the leaves are an indication that the soil has been kept too wet. Drooping leaves are evidence that you need to water the plant. Do not wait for the leaves to begin shriveling up before you water. Dry, brown edges are another sign that the plant has been kept too dry for too long.
- **Light:** Bright, indirect light is all it requires. Low-light areas and locations with florescent light, such as offices and dorm rooms will do fine. If you have a variegated cultivar, it may revert to completely green leaves if it doesn't get enough light. Place the plant in a brighter location and the variegation should come back. Pale leaves are an indication that it is receiving too much light.
- **Temperature and Humidity:** Ideal temperatures are 50 degrees Fahrenheit. This plant is adaptable, so temperatures at 65 to 75 degrees Fahrenheit are acceptable. Pothos prefer high humidity, and bathrooms or kitchens make a great location in your home. Place the plant next to a humidifier periodically.



(Photo: Canva)



(Photo: Canva)

- **Fertilizer:** Pothos are not heavy feeders, but potting soil has very little nutrients. A bi-monthly feeding of a balanced fertilizer is all you need. It is good to refrain from feeding the plant during its dormant winter months.
- **Propagation:** The process to create more plants is easy. All you need is a stem cutting. To take a stem cutting, you need to cut just below a node on the stem. Place the cutting in water and sit back and watch the roots form. When you have well-established roots, transplant the cutting in a pot with potting soil.

Problems and Solutions

- **Pest:** It is usually a pest-free plant, but occasionally mealybugs can be a problem. If this happens, a simple insecticidal soap is your go-to product to manage them. As always, follow all instructions on the product label when applying.
- **Toxicity:** Beware, pothos plants are toxic to both people and pets if chewed or ingested. It is not necessarily deadly, but it can cause digestion problems and skin irritations.



Mealy bugs. (Photo: Canva)

Reference and Resource

Pothos (*Epipremnum aureum*), University of Wisconsin Extension.

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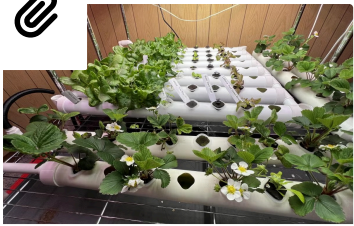
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